

Is AI truly bad for the environment?

Posted by u/derpling0719 • 0 points • 7 comments

If so, how? I'm not very tech savvy, so I really don't understand. Unless it's about energy consumption, which I can understand.

It started with something I read that said something like "People need to stop saying thank you to AI" because it "wreaks havoc on the environment."

When I look for clarification, I don't really find anything definitive. Or maybe I just don't understand all the technical terms.

Can someone help me understand? Thank you!

Comments

u/NergalTheGreat • 1 points • 2025-09-19 15:36 UTC

> It started with something I read that said something like "People need to stop saying thank you to AI" because it "wreaks havoc on the environment."

That is a perfect example of greenwashing. It costs the businesses that opera AI a bunch of money.

u/maybri • 1 points • 2025-09-19 15:15 UTC

Energy consumption is the most obvious thing (AI is *very* energy intensive--there are probably large numbers of people whose ChatGPT energy use exceeds the energy use of their car). It also produces large amounts of waste in hardware that fails and needs to be replaced, and the cooling systems require large amounts of water, which can strain municipal water supplies in drought-prone areas.

u/hilburn • 1 points • 2025-09-19 15:10 UTC

Remember - the AI doesn't know you are thanking it, the amount of processing it does is basically the same whether you are saying "thank you" vs asking for it to write a 500 word short story about a gay penguin finding love.

Basically, if everyone thanks it after asking a question, you can halve the power consumption per question by getting everyone to stop thanking it.

That said, I'm pretty sure they've implemented filters to prevent it actually doing the full computation on a simple "thank you" message

u/noggin-scratcher • 1 points • 2025-09-19 15:08 UTC

Primarily about energy consumption by the server farms that the system runs on. Each query to an AI requires a moderately substantial amount of computation which consumes some energy (commonly cited numbers say it's maybe about 10× the amount compared to running a standard Google search).

"Saying thank you to AI" is mentioned because there's a counter-intuitive effect. When you say thanks to a human at the end of an interaction, it's an easy weightless little politeness that doesn't cost them anything to respond with an automatic "you're welcome", but for the AI system it takes _the entire context of the conversation so far_, plus "thank you" on the end, and feeds that whole thing through another run of inference. Which makes it just as weighty/costly as any other follow-up query that has to process the whole context window again.

Probably the makers of AI chatbots need, if they haven't already, to program in a filter list for common ways of saying "thank you", to detect those queries and auto-respond to them, without invoking the whole AI model for another run.

u/illogictc • 1 points • 2025-09-19 15:03 UTC

It is indeed about the energy use involved. Especially when more complicated inputs are given to it because it has to parse all that and generate a response. We have companies striking deals to reopen shuttered nuclear plants to satisfy the energy demand they're foreseeing.

Is it a tool? Yes. Is it a useful tool? Can be yes. But it should be treated with a little respect for the fact that it's just a tool and the computational overhead involved before doing shit like having AI girlfriends, and yes that's apparently something that actually fucking happens.

In the future, provided more energy-efficient hardware and/or software hits the industry, and combined with more green energy investment, it might not be such a big deal.

u/AccountNumber478 • 2 points • 2025-09-19 15:03 UTC

My understanding is that it hits the environment and power generation.

Environment, because AI data centers get constructed which apparently can cause issues for local residents with both the construction aspect and stuff like light pollution and other stuff (based on some story I saw recently in the popular feed).

Power generation, because now with Copilot and Google for example you can use them like a search engine, and on the other end is something an order of magnitude or few more computationally expensive. That multiplied by however many people on the internet want to ask whatever stupid-ass questions day after day, minute after minute, adds up to lots of energy expenditure. If humanity can finally, after decades and decades of wishful thinking, stand up viable nuclear fusion, it'll surely be less of an issue, but with fossil fuels ever declining in availability, presumably the drain is more alarming now than ever.

u/Agreeable-Ad1221 • 2 points • 2025-09-19 15:01 UTC

It uses a lot of energy, which is typically from fossil fuels, and the computing equipment needs constant cooling which uses up a lot of fresh water.